

FACT FILE

GETTING THERE

Fly to Cochin International Airport at Nedumbassery and drive 3.5–4 hrs to Munnar, 115 km away

From Kochi, drive 238 km to Wayanad or fly to Kozhikode for the 62 km/2-hr drive to Lakkidi on the eastern flank of Wayanad

DO

Lockhart Tea Factory
8 am–5 pm, Entry: ₹250/head

Srishti Centre for the Differently Abled, Munnar
Handmade eco-paper, hand dyed fabric
9 am–5 pm, Entry: ₹60
Ph 04868-255398, 9497473397
www.srishti-trust.org

Herping/Birding Trails
Munnar/Wayanad

STAY

Lockhart Bungalow
Harrisons Malayalam Estate, Devikulam
Rs 21,192 + taxes

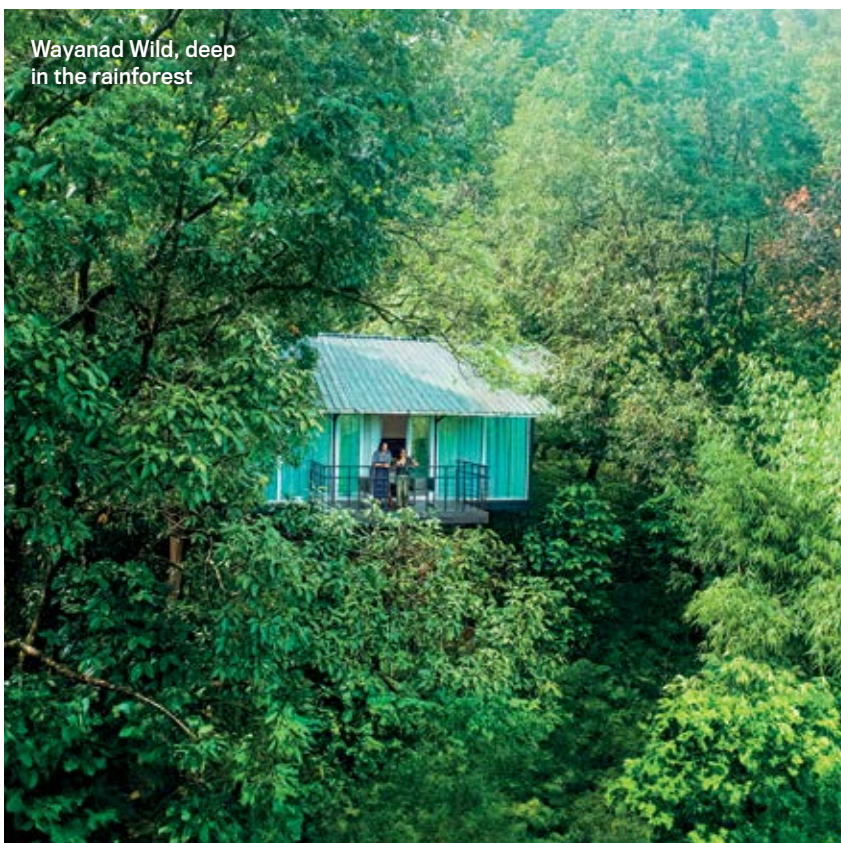
Chittoor Kottaram
Near Chittoor Krishna Temple
₹28,813 + taxes

Beach Gate Bungalows
Fort Kochi
₹18,008 + taxes

Wayanad Wild
Lakkidi, Wayanad
Tariff ₹9,336 upwards + taxes
Contact: 0484-4261711/2, 080-69807579,
www.cghearth.com

From the high ranges, we descended to the backwaters for a royal retreat by the waterfront. Chittoor Kottaram was the erstwhile residence of the Maharaja of Cochin whenever he visited the Chittoor Krishna Temple with his entourage. Befittingly, caretaker Milton welcomes guests warmly with garlands and caparisoned parasols. The single-key hotel has three rooms overlooking a lush garden patch with an idyllic pool and private jetty. After a *sadya* (a lush spread on a banana leaf), we set out with Antony on a leisurely boat ride through the canals of the Periyar river. With fresh rainwater inundating the backwaters, the Chinese fishing nets were idle due to the lull in fishing. But the aquatic birds patrolled the waters for a good catch. Darters, cormorants, kingfishers and herons perched patiently by the edge and on wooden stumps, swooping down in a flash to break the still reflections into a thousand ripples. Dinner that night was a sensational Kerala meal of veg pulao, chicken curry and karimeen pollichathu stirred up by chef Sajida.

The recently launched heritage Beach Gate Bungalows in Fort Kochi is a great base in town for a self-reliant holiday. The independent European-style twin bungalows were built in the 1950s for the Sterling Companies in Cochin. Each bungalow has three rooms, a sunken dining room by the pool, a fully equipped kitchen, and balconies overlooking a tropical garden shaded by massive jackfruit and rain trees. A dedicated butler is on call to bring food from CGH Earth's colonial hotel Eighth Bastion, a five-minute stroll away. We uncovered Fort Kochi's secrets on a heritage walk—Petercelli Street was named after the Dutch word for 'parsley'! Then we checked out the local sights on a tuk-tuk tour—St Francis Church, the oldest European church in India where Vasco Da Gama was laid to rest in 1524, Santa Cruz Cathedral Basilica, Indian Naval Maritime Museum, Bastion Bungalow Museum and Mattancherry Palace. ■



Wayanad Wild, deep in the rainforest